

Last time we introduced the question of what we should believe. We began by considering this rule of belief:

No Proof $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't give a good
argument for P, don't
believe P.

But we saw that this led to the result that you should not believe anything at all, which seems very implausible.

At the very least, it seems, we should believe things that we can be certain of:

Certainty $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you can rule out any situation which would make P false, you should believe P.

Experience → Belief

If your sense experience tells you that P, and you have no reason to think that your sense experience is misleading, you should believe P.

Good Argument $\rightarrow$ Belief

If there is a valid argument for P and you should believe each of that argument's premises, you should believe P.

Suppose that these are all true. This still leaves us without any plausible negative rules of belief: rules which tell us when to discard beliefs that we already have. And it seems like there must be some rules of this kind, since it seems like one thing we ought to be able to do is to examine our beliefs to see which ones we should discard.

But the above suggests a plausible candidate for such a rule. Maybe I should believe what (i) I can be certain of, (ii) what my senses tell me, and (iii) what I can argue for on the basis of (i) and (ii), and **that's all**.

This is a version of a view known as foundationalism.

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